

Tom Clancy's **ruthless.com**

Strategy Guide

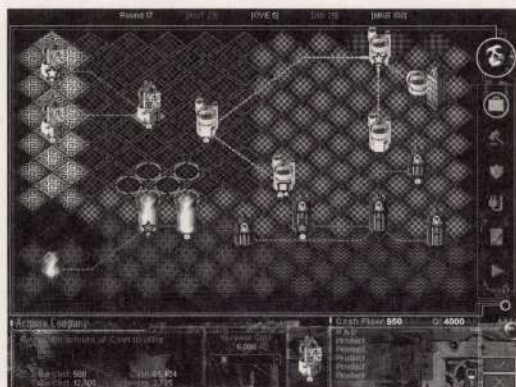


This isn't business.
This is war.



Strategy Guide

Introduction



Knowing what to do and being able to do it are sometimes two different things.

the time and that can help you increase your share of the market, your income, and your ability to compete with your rival Corporations.

ruthless.com is a large game where it often seems there is too much to do and not enough time to do it. You will often feel like you don't have enough actions on each turn to accomplish everything you need to do. What this means is that prioritization of your actions is important so that you can get the most benefit from those actions you do take.

Every game of ruthless.com is different. There is no magical formula that will guarantee victory every time. However, there are some strategies that will work much of

Take Down EvilSoft

Your goal in this scenario is to have the Corporation with the largest market share by the end of the game, whether by hook or by crook. Generally speaking, this implies that you will have significant amounts of Cash on hand, but this is not necessary. All that is important is that your Corporation be the one controlling the largest part of the market at the end of the game. It will be considerably easier if you do this with significant amounts of Cash, but it is possible to win with a negative Cash flow or a negative balance.

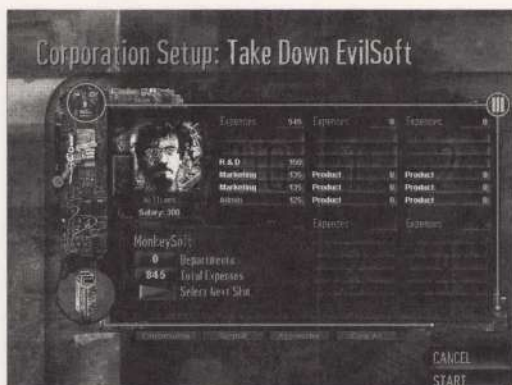
The biggest mistake that most people make in this scenario is gunning for EvilSoft right away. This is a strategy destined to fail. Rather than go after them, use the beginning of the scenario to go after your fellow start-up Corporations. EvilSoft has a tremendous advantage over you, with 10 Buildings already in place, powerful Product and more. On the other hand, your neighboring small fry are in the same position you are, and they are easier pickings. Go wholeheartedly after your closest neighbor and absorb their Corporation. With this added muscle, you can easily take out another new Corporation, adding it to

your expanding empire. With the cumulative might of two or three Corporations on your side, you have the ability to go full-out for EvilSoft.

Start planning this from the very beginning. You have three Buildings and 10 Departments. Your HQ needs to have an Admin Department. Your other nine Departments should be divided between Marketing, R&D and Products. Give your HQ and your first subsidiary at least one of each—two Marketing and one R&D in each is a good start. In your third Building, put three Products. When it comes time to set up your Corporation, place your HQ, then your first subsidiary near it. Your third Building should be placed as a subsidiary to your second so that it gets the benefit of the Marketing and R&D Departments in its two parent companies. This third Building should be placed in such a way that it maximizes the amount of area it covers and stays out of the center of the market area, since this will be controlled by EvilSoft.

With only 10 Departments, you have some ability to build your Buildings up from here. Your Building controlling your Products should have a much greater effective Quality than everything around it with the exception of EvilSoft. Use your first couple of turns to add a few more Departments—more Marketing is a good idea to keep boosting that effective Quality, and an Acquisitions Department is a good idea as well.

What you want to do is drive one of your competitors to the brink of ruin. As his Corporation loses money and his stock price declines, you can look to acquire his



This is aggressive in terms of product quality, and should give you a jump start.



By attacking other small corporations, you can build your power base.

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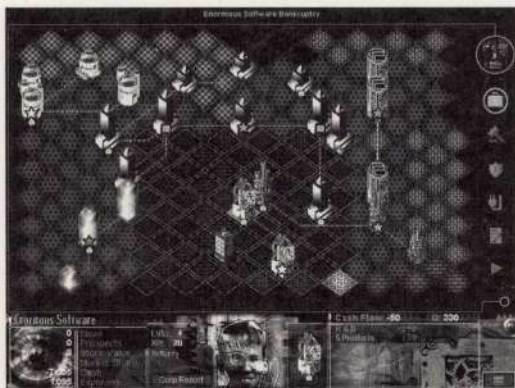
Buildings with your Acquisitions Department. Money should be no object here—remember that the goal of the scenario is to become the largest Corporation, not the richest one. Buy the Buildings that have Products, and use your Marketing Departments to move your Buildings around so that there is as little overlap as possible. Restructuring your Corporation so that your recent acquisitions can benefit from the Marketing and R&D Departments in your HQ and direct subsidiary is a good idea as well.

Move one of your Product-bearing Buildings against another Corporation now and use the same strategy. As you steal his market share and money, his stock price will decline, allowing you to snap up his Buildings for very little.

At this point, since you have additional Buildings, you can look to develop some of the more interesting Departments. A Computer Core or two will allow you to access some of the secrets at EvilSoft and put a dent in their money-making machinery, while Legal Departments can give you the benefit of patent claims, preventing additional Marketing or Products from EvilSoft from taking over your empire. Security measures are also worthwhile. As you rise quickly in power, you will become the target of EvilSoft's machinations, so keep your Buildings as protected as possible. If you haven't gained an HR and an empty Admin Department or two, build them, and place the Admins (and the Executives you hire) in Buildings controlling Security, Legal and Computer

Core Departments so that they can utilize these Departments every turn without having your CEO turn away from your main business of getting your Products to as much of the market as possible.

As the game progresses, you should be making a pretty good amount of money with a lot of your products. When you are in the position of being the largest of the start-up companies, it's time to make your move against EvilSoft. What you are going to do is damage your own Cash standing by stealing away the EvilSoft market.



Bankruptcies are golden opportunities to gain market share and Buildings

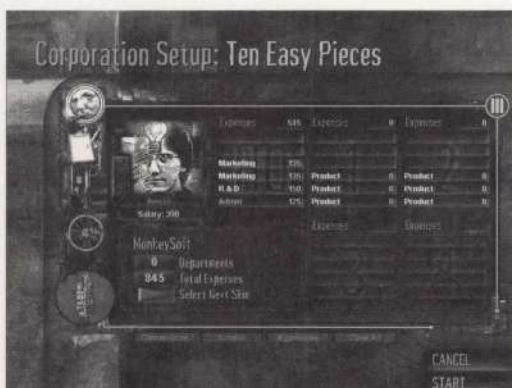
Use one of your Marketing Departments to start moving one of your Buildings bearing a number of Products into EvilSoft market territory. To take away his market share, have one of your R&D Departments release the source code for the Products in that Building. This will completely drain away any money that Building is bringing in, but it will give your effective Quality an incredible boost, more than likely taking away huge pieces of EvilSoft's market. Keep moving that Building into EvilSoft territory to take more and more of their market away, and use your Legal Departments to put down some patents on those market share tiles. If you are playing against a more difficult AI, you might want to move your Buildings into position and release the source code on the last turn, stealing the market share before EvilSoft can react.

Ten Easy Pieces

While your starting situation is the same as in the first scenario, not much else is for this game. Here, your goal is the same—become the Corporation with the largest market share. The main difference is that EvilSoft is gone, and the ten Buildings that made up that Corporation are now individual start-ups. Because of this, acquisition in the early stages is going to take a much more important role in your plans. You'll be doing some acquisition early and often in this scenario, so a CEO with the "ruthless" trait is a good choice.

Start by creating your Buildings in much the same way as you did for the Take Down EvilSoft scenario, with one significant change. Rather than overloading on Marketing, replace one of these Departments with an Acquisitions Department. This will enable you to start increasing the size of your Corporation from the first turn.

And acquisition should be the name of the game, at least initially. Taking over start-up companies is quick and cheap—cheaper by far than starting your own new Building, which runs 7,500 Cash. On your first few turns, use your



Drop a Marketing Department in favor of Acquisitions at the start up.

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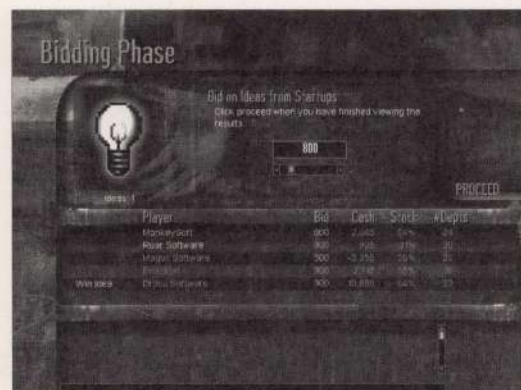
Acquisitions Department to pick up a few of the Buildings that were a part of EvilSoft. Concentrate first on getting those Buildings that hold Products, since this will give you additional Cash. These Buildings will go fairly quickly, so you must act quickly—on your first and second turn if possible. After this, with an extra Building or two in your pocket, you should be bringing in a decent income. You can further increase the size of your Corporation by picking up an extra Building or two from the former EvilSoft.



Acquire, acquire, acquire! It's the easiest way to gain market share.

yourself. Many of the Buildings that used to be a part of EvilSoft will have multiple Computer Cores, Security or Legal Departments, additional Acquisition Departments, HR or Admin Departments.

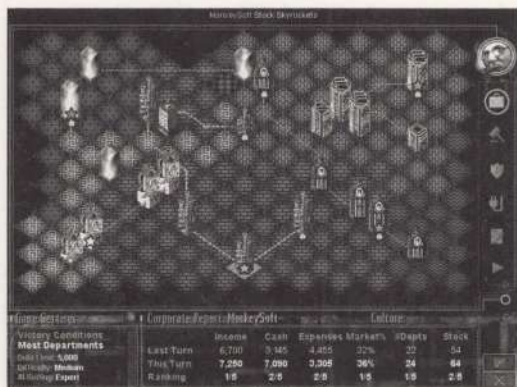
Once you have a large collection of Buildings, it's time to start working to maximize your profit so you can continue to grow. Additional Marketing in your HQ and subsidiary will pass down the effects to your Product-bearing Buildings, keeping your effective Quality high. Use your Marketing Departments to move your Buildings so that you control as much of the market as possible. Not only will this bring in additional Cash every turn, but you will steal market share away from your competition. This can help drive their stock price down, allowing you to either bankrupt them or give you a chance to grab pieces of enemy Corporations for cheap.



If you can buy an idea for less than 1000 Cash, you've made a steal.

You should also keep in mind your ability to use those Departments you picked up with your Acquisition Department. A lawsuit

can keep your opponent Corporations busy with something other than keeping their profit level high. Initially, the best use of your Computer Cores and Security Departments is to keep your own Buildings safe. If you haven't picked up an HR Department, you might want to consider creating one and putting Admin Departments in those Buildings with the specialized Departments. This will allow you to issue legal, security or computer orders without having to have your CEO give up capitalizing on the ability to add more Product or Quality to your main source of income.



Product-filled Buildings can dominate huge portions of the market.

Your initial ten Departments and three Buildings will give you a good number of Departments, and picking up at least three of the Buildings that were a part of EvilSoft will allow you to create as many as 36 Departments. Keeping several Buildings around filled with nothing but Product backed by a number of R&D and Marketing Departments will allow them to cover a huge expanse of the market. Many times, two Buildings with six Products each, attached to your network of Marketing and R&D will have the ability to control nearly half of the market, which should be enough to win. If it isn't, keep picking up those start-ups and adding them into the network, and attack your enemies so that their Product-bearing Buildings are easy to snap up, giving you more Product and more market share.

Empire Building

Empire Building is much like Ten Easy Pieces except that you don't have the advantage of having ten well-developed start-up Buildings to pick up at the start of the scenario. Instead, you and your competitor Corporations start small and against each other. However, acquiring new Buildings will still be the centerpiece of your strategy here. Start with Marketing, R&D and Product Departments, not worrying too much about acquisitions on your first turn. Instead, look to maximize both your Quality and your market share initially, and make as much Cash as possible. A "ruthless" CEO is a good choice, since you

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You don't have much to start with here, so make the most of your few Departments.

your actions to build an Acquisitions Department. Start-up Buildings will start appearing almost immediately. Since your goal is to have the largest Corporation at the end of the scenario, it makes sense to pick up these Buildings as soon as you can. However, this doesn't mean that you should pick up just any new start-up

will be acquiring new Buildings frequently. Since Cash is also important with the amount you will be spending, a "salesman" CEO is also an excellent choice. When laying out your Buildings at the beginning of the scenario, be aggressive and put your third, Product-bearing Building as close to the middle of the game board as you can. This will allow you to control as much of the market as possible at the expense of the other Corporations.

Regardless of what the market looks like on the first turn, use one of

your actions to build an Acquisitions Department. Start-up Buildings will start appearing almost immediately. Since your goal is to have the largest Corporation at the end of the scenario, it makes sense to pick up these Buildings as soon as you can. However, this doesn't mean that you should pick up just any new start-up that appears. Concentrate on grabbing ones that already have a good income, since this additional Cash will be important in picking up additional Buildings and in adding Departments to the Buildings you have.

One good way to continually increase your Corporate size at the expense of your rival Corporations is to reorganize your structure so that new Product-bearing acquisitions are connected in to the network in such a way that they can enjoy the benefits of the Marketing

and R&D Departments in your HQ and main subsidiary. Bid high to pick up new ideas during the idea bidding phase and use one of your R&D Departments to create new ideas on a regular basis. These new ideas can be turned into Product Departments on every turn.



Getting your Acquisitions Department working is critical to your success.

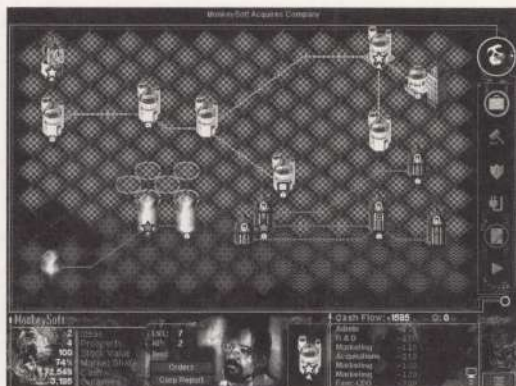
This has several positive benefits for you. First, adding Products increases the amount of the market you can cover with your Products, taking Cash away from your competition. Second, adding Products to your Buildings adds to the overall Quality of these Buildings, helping to guarantee that you will be in control of those market share tiles that you are fighting over. Third, and in some ways most importantly in this scenario, adding Products gives you additional Departments, increasing the overall size of your Corporation.

Since this is the ultimate goal of this scenario, adding a Department on virtually every turn will continue to help increase the size of your Corporation.

If you can act quickly, buying up start-up Buildings quickly and adding additional Products to your Buildings on almost every turn, you can often develop at such a rate that the other Corporations can't keep up. In fact, quick action combined with high effective Quality and a huge number of Products will give you such a significant advantage over the other Corporations that even generating the Cash to stay solvent will be difficult for your opponents. This scenario, more than any other, gives you the opportunity to concentrate solely on Marketing, R&D and Products, forgoing the normal production of the Computer Core, Security and Legal Departments. It's difficult for your enemies to attack you when they don't have the Cash on hand or the income to produce these Departments in the first place.

Strike It Rich

Money makes the world go around, and it's the main concern of this scenario as well. The Corporation that amasses the highest amount of



Over time, with good acquisitions, you can quickly dominate the market.



In a game where Cash is king, powerful Product is key.

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Cash by the end of the scenario will be the winner. Because of this, select a CEO who gives you the ability to save as much as possible or make as much as possible. "Frugal" is an excellent choice, since this lowers the cost of every action you take, while "salesman" gives you additional income on every turn. Naturally, if you can find an Executive that has both of these qualities, it is the best situation.

You don't have a lot to work with at the start of this scenario, but that's fine. A single Marketing and one R&D Department in your HQ is a necessity. Not only will this help keep your Product Quality high, it allows you to add similar Departments to the HQ for only 1,000 Cash. Put the rest of your Departments in your second Building and make these all Products.

The biggest mistake that you can make in this scenario is to be afraid to spend money when you need to. While amassing wealth is the main goal of this scenario, the axiom that it takes money to make money was never truer. Don't be afraid to run in the red for the first few turns if doing so will enable you to turn a huge profit later in the game.



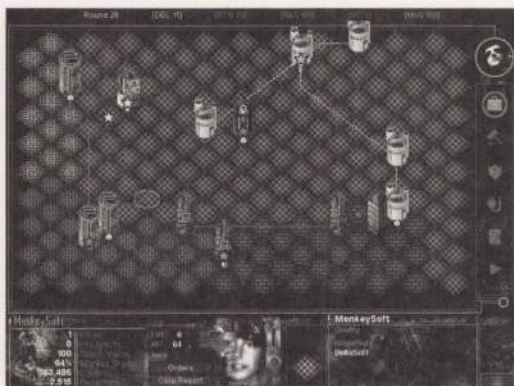
Keep your Product Quality high with your Marketing Departments.

decent price you can bring in more money by adding Product to your Buildings without having to use your R&D Departments to develop the ideas on your own. This is all for the better if you can manage to get the ideas for less than the 1,000 Cash it normally costs to develop an idea.

Because Cash is so important in this scenario, Product Quality is equally important. Only by keeping your Product Quality as high as possible is critical to your

Start-up Buildings will appear throughout the game. Building an Acquisitions Department is a good idea, since grabbing a few Buildings that are turning a profit will naturally help you keep your Cash coming in. You might want to consider allowing a couple of these Buildings to stick around for a few turns. If they are left alone, there is a good chance they will develop R&D Departments and will offer ideas for sale every turn. Bid high for these, but not too high. Still, if you can grab a few ideas for a

overall position. You can help ensure this by building a few QA labs in your R&D Department in your Corporate HQ. While this will reduce your Product Quality for a couple of turns, you will recoup it quickly and will start adding Quality. Fill up the rest of your HQ with Marketing Departments, and make sure that as many of your subsidiaries are connected into the HQ as possible. Because you don't have the luxury of having a second building in your structure to add Marketing and R&D benefits to your Products, consider adding a Marketing Department or two to your Product-bearing Buildings. This will add additional benefits to those Products. Having four or five Products in those Buildings won't allow you to increase your market share as much as possible with those Buildings, it will have a dramatic effect on your Product Quality.



Controlling market share equates to bringing in tremendous Cash.

The Duel

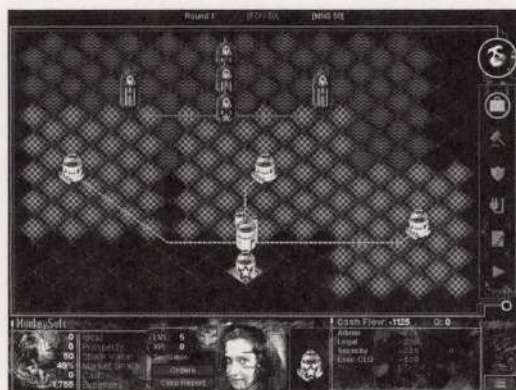
The Duel is a quick and dirty game where you face off against a single Corporation in a battle for dominance of the entire market. Your starting position is critical in this scenario, since a favorable start where you control the lion's share of the market will give you significant advantages over your rival. You will be concentrating the bulk of your Products in three Buildings at the start, using your other two to boost Product Quality and keep yourself protected from your enemy's machinations.



You can afford to be aggressive here to steal market share immediately.

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To win this scenario, it is important to get your Product Quality high immediately and keep it high. You'll be using your Products to go aggressively after the other Corporation from the start. Since there are only two Corporations in the game, you want to take as much market share as possible at the expense of your competitor. Not only will this increase your stock price, it will help drop his stock price down, which will become important several turns into the game. To help with this, pack your HQ and first subsidiary Building with R&D and especially Marketing Departments. Hook the other three Buildings into this first subsidiary so that they reap the benefits of the Marketing and R&D Departments you have created. Place these Buildings in such a way as to take over a large part of the market with as little overlap as possible. More importantly, place



By keeping Quality high, you can destroy the stock price of your competitor.

them to take over as much of the center of the market area as you can. This will allow you to aggressively attack the position of your rival Corporation, stealing away their market share.

Having the superior position at the start of the game is important to your eventual success. Add Marketing Departments immediately, and use your R&D to create ideas so that you can add Product. These will help you bring in additional market share tiles, much at the expense of your rival.

As you take over more and more of the market, your rival Corporation will see his share of the market diminish. This will have negative effects on his overall position and will slowly cause his stock price to decline. Add an Acquisition Department when his stock price dips dramatically and check out his Buildings. When you have the Cash, which shouldn't take too long with the amount of money you are bringing in on a turn-by-turn basis, start offering to purchase pieces of his Corporation. Wait until the stock price is low enough that you don't need to offer a lot of Cash at any one time, and work to buy his Products as soon as you can, since this will give you more income and reduce the amount of Cash he is bringing in. Offer double the normal purchase price so that you are guaranteed to get the Buildings.

With his Products stripped away, it becomes simply a battle of attrition that you are guaranteed to win.

Armageddon

This is a difficult and interesting scenario. Your goal is to become the last standing Corporation in a shrinking market. To do this, you must be aggressive and ruthless against your enemies. You must plan to attack the center of the market to keep these valuable tiles under your control. Unlike the other scenarios, you will not need to actively attack your competition. Instead, you are looking simply to win the battle of attrition that will occur as the market disappears.

Place your Product-bearing Building toward the center of the game board to take over these central market share tiles. Your other Departments should again be divided between Marketing and R&D Departments to keep your Product Quality high. Two R&D Departments are a good idea in this scenario, and you should consider adding an Acquisition Department early on.

Initially, there isn't a lot that you will be doing with your actions. Instead of doing nothing, you can add QA labs to your R&D Departments, which will help increase your Product Quality in the center of the market. As start-up Buildings appear, use that Acquisitions Department to snap them up and keep them out of the hands of your enemies.

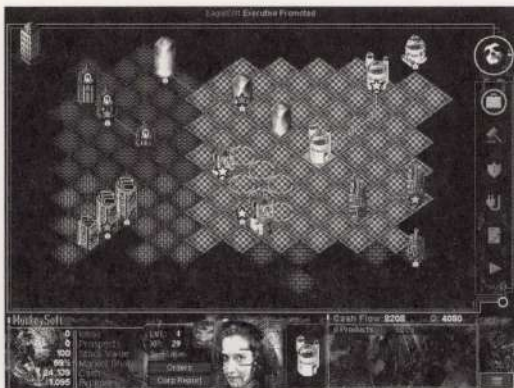


Prepare for a quick and deadly battle in the Armageddon scenario.



As the market shrinks, controlling what is available is your main goal.

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Even in a shrinking market, there's money to be made every turn.

the market that is left. While this will affect your effective Quality, you will continue to increase your amount of Cash. As the other Corporations begin to lose market share, move your Buildings in to take even more of their market. The goal is to make them die off, usually slowly and painfully as your Buildings take the market that is left. Don't worry about the more specialized Departments—you won't have time to use them effectively. Instead, concentrate on increasing your amount of Products and using your Marketing Departments to maneuver your Buildings into favorable positions.



Only three departments doesn't offer much room for flexibility.

With powerful Product, you have a good chance at outlasting your enemies. Couple this with your ability to add start-up Buildings into your Corporate structure and you will soon have a dominant position in the market.

As the game progresses and market share dries up, use your Marketing Departments to move your Buildings around the game board to control more and more of the diminishing market. Your goal is to continue to move your Buildings around to maximize the amount of

Campaign

With a little planning and a little luck, you can complete the Campaign game in ruthless.com quickly and efficiently. Your goal is to take at least 75% of the market and hold it for at least four consecutive turns. To do this, you will need a lot of products strategically placed in the market and a good number of R & D and Marketing Departments. An acquisitions Department will be critical as well.

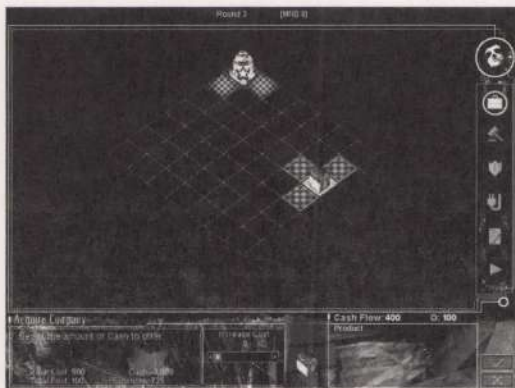
While you start with only three Departments, you do have a significant advantage in that you are the only corporation around at the start. This gives you the ability to snap up those start-up companies as soon as they become available. You are going to be running in the red for several turns, so hiring an Executive who has the Banker trait is a pretty good idea.

Your first Building should start with an Admin, Product and R&D Department. What you are going to do is keep this running small until start-up companies start entering the market. Your first moves will get you ready to take over other companies when they appear.

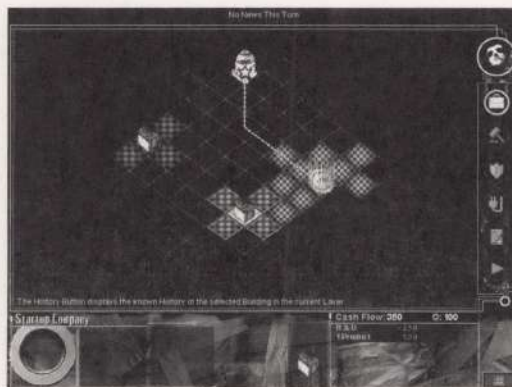
Place your Building roughly in the center of the screen. This will allow you to cover the maximum number of squares with your one product. On this first turn, build a new Acquisitions Department and use your other action to build a QA lab in your R&D Department.

You'll be running at a loss. That's okay for now. New start-up companies will start appearing almost immediately, usually on the second turn. Start buying them with your Acquisitions Department and adding them onto your Corporate structure. When you have the money to do so, transfer the Product from your Corporate HQ to one of your new subsidiaries so the R&D Department will pass its effect downstream. This prevents the need for these Departments in each of your Product-bearing Buildings.

Your next few turns should be spent acquiring start-ups with your Acquisitions Department and slowly

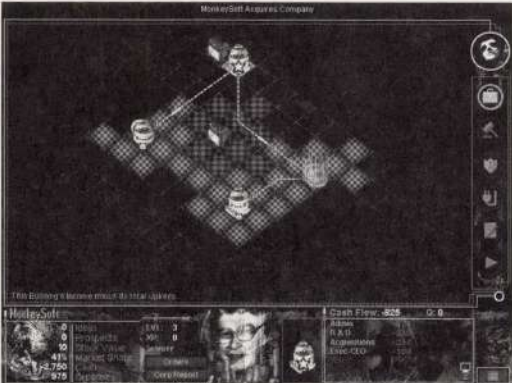


An Acquisitions Department offers ways to increase your Cash flow quickly.



Don't hesitate to snap up the start-ups that appear frequently.

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You should quickly establish a network of Products on the limited market area.

be important as the scenario progresses. While one of them keeps the effective Quality of the Products in the subsidiary Buildings high, the other will be used to move your Buildings around the market. As the market changes in size, you will want to reposition your Buildings to take advantage of new market share tiles. Additionally, you want to avoid overlap between your Buildings' Products as much as possible.

New Corporations will start up periodically to challenge you. However, with your head start, you should not have too much trouble preventing them from getting close to your power. Move your Buildings to tiles close by these new Corporations so that your superior Quality will take their tiles away from them.



As the market expands, keep moving your Products to grab more tiles.

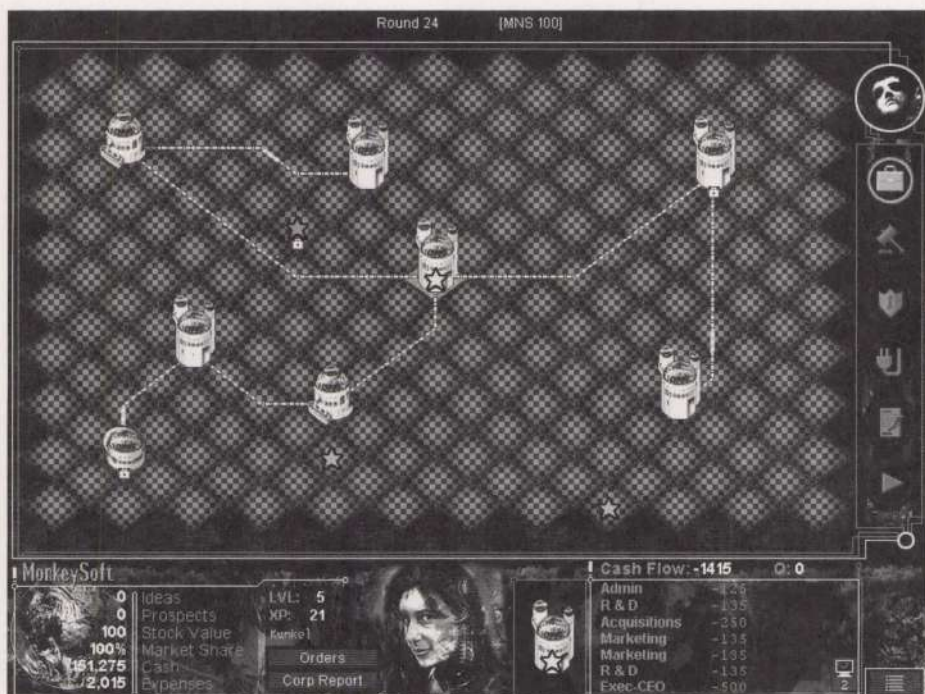
rebuilding your Cash to a positive total. When you have the money to do so, build a Marketing Department in your Corporate HQ.

Subsequent turns will consist of combinations of the following orders: creating ideas, building products, purchasing start-ups and moving your Buildings with your Marketing Department. It's a good idea to add a second R&D and a second Marketing Department to your HQ when you get the chance.

Your Marketing Departments will Keep snapping up new companies as they appear. You might want to make an exception or two for start-ups that also have R&D Departments. You'll be able to purchase their ideas in the Idea Bidding Phase for next to nothing on each turn.

By turn 20, you should have close to a stranglehold on the market. Continue to move your Buildings

as needed to take over more market share. If you don't have a significant percentage of the market at this point, you can start building Security, Computer Core and Legal Departments to help combat other Corporations, but the most important thing is to add more Products and take over more market share.



This is the ultimate ruthless.com accomplishment--100% market share, a maximized stock price and no more competition. A complete monopoly of the market is tough to accomplish, but is a worthy goal.

Red Storm Entertainment's Tip Line

All the hints, tricks, and cheats!

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parents' permission.**

Touchtone phones only.

1-900-288-2583 (CLUE).

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